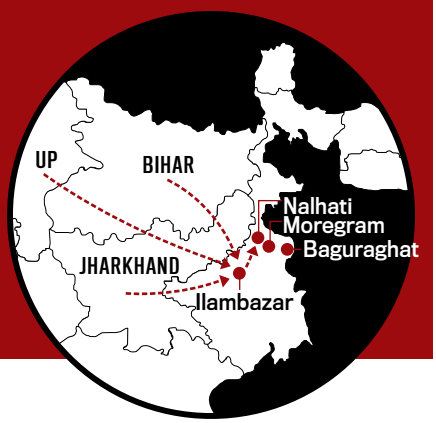
THE MOOLAH

On a weekly haat day, if 5,000 cows are sold, the earning could be as much as Rs 25 crore, as across the border in Bangladesh, the cows fetch Rs 50-75 crore. The smuggling syndicate claims Rs 10-15 crore from it

THE ROUTE

From Jharkhand, Bihar and UP to Ilambazar in Birbhum–Nalhati (Lohapur haat)–Moregram in Murshidabad–finally Umarpur (Murshidabad)–Baguraghat (last point in Bengal) before crossing the Ganga/ Padma river into Bangladesh



taken by specialists who know the lay of the land and the many palms they have to grease at various junctures. Police chowkis allegedly take Rs 500 from every truck and Rs 200 from smaller vehicles. Birbhum alone has 27 such points on the smugglers' payroll.

On the border, cattle are either made to cross the Ganga into Bangladesh on a pontoon bridge of boats, or gently floated across it after being secured with banana piths. Technology has a peep in too: sources say sometimes microchips are attached to the animals' horns to ensure they do not stray. A 25-year-old cowherd, who was once part of the racket, says that earlier, "Rakhals were given a torn piece of 10 rupee note or a cigarette packet with numbers as code. Only if the receiver could provide the remaining piece of the note and match the codes could he claim the consignment." The receiver also checked out the sender's stamp on the back of the ox/ cow.

There are also smugglers who operate on their own, outside the allegedly well-oiled police-politician-BSF nexus. When caught with contraband by the BSF—and hundreds of heads of cattle are confiscated—a different game is said to play out. The numbers are shown to be far less in the books, and then they are auctioned to a select few...to be smuggled again through the proper 'channel'. Villagers of Sagardighi in Murshidabad talk of cattle seized by the BSF during the day disappearing at night. "Trucks find a safe shelter outside BSF camps. Next morning we see boats creating a *phorash* (bridge) on the river, with the cattle crossing over to Bangladesh."

A political leader from Murshidabad makes another allegation. "Often," he says, "BSF and the customs office at Umarpur auction the seized cattle and Enamul's men take part in the auction to buy a cow/ ox at a dirt-cheap rate of Rs 8,000, to be smuggled later for Rs 1.5 lakh."

THE DRAMATIS PERSONAE

Over the past decade, many head of cattle being smuggled across the border have apparently been stamped with the letter 'H', the initial for 'Hingur', an alias of Latif uses. He rose from a cowherd supplying straws at the Sukhbazar *poshu haat* to become Enamul's right-hand man in the smuggling racket, allegedly helping him procure cows as well as keeping the police and administrative chain primed for a smooth operation. After Enamul's arrest in February, his diary gave the CBI a clearer idea of Mondal's role in the racket.

The two supplementary chargesheets submitted by the CBI (the latest in August) mention the alleged involvement of a section of the Bengal police, administration, businessmen and the BSF in the racket. The CBI arrested BSF officer Satish Kumar, a former commandant of the 36th battalion, earlier this year for his alleged role in the racket. He got bail after 28 days. Three more BSF officers are being probed. The ED, for its part, has also zeroed in on some IPS officers, suspecting them of being part of the racket.

One of the main accused is former police constable Saigal Hossain. With Mondal's rise in the party, Hossain became his personal bodyguard and man Friday. Hossain's name figures prominently in the CBI chargesheet for being an intermediary between Enamul and Mondal. Hossain would allegedly collect money from both Enamul and Latif on behalf of Mondal for his all-important patronage to the racket. If Enamul's diary gave CBI officers enough clues about Mondal's alleged involvement, the call detail records from Hossain's phones reveal more details, drawing the net closer around Mondal. They have helped establish a connection between Enamul, Latif and Hossain. All calls for Mondal regarding cattle smuggling came on Hossain's phones.

According to the CBI chargesheet, Hossain collected Rs 62,000 for a pair of smuggled cattle on behalf of Mondal from Latif and Enamul. The money feeds a long chain—from police stations, officials, panchayat members to politicians. The high amount spent on kickbacks is not a deterrent, given the three or four times the price the cattle fetch on the other side of the fence.

A TMC insider alleges that Mondal netted Rs 10-20 crore a month from cattle smuggling, a substantial portion of which went to Kolkata in tin containers meant for packing puffed rice. "Keshto *da* (Mondal) would openly say he is responsible for generating Rs 200 crore annually from Birbhum, of which cattle smuggling alone fetched Rs 100 crore. He flaunted such numbers to show how indispensable he was to the party," alleges another TMC councillor, an old associate of his. Mondal, of course, vehemently denies all allegations.

Meanwhile, Hossain did not just put his phones at Mondal's service, he also lent his name and those of his relatives for allegedly parking Mondal's assets. As per documents available